

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Budget OK'd, minus big loan

After months of contentious debate, board shuns Johnson's pressure to borrow \$200M

DEFICIT FALLOUT

CPS won't ensure pension payments, leaving city in bigger hole, mayor says

By A.D. Quig | Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Friday unveiled a \$1.15 billion deficit for 2026, an unsurprising but still formidable hurdle heading into his third budget.

Having taken a 2026 property tax hike — which faced long odds of success in a restive City Council in any event — off the table, Johnson heads into the fall budget season still talking about “progressive revenue” to close the yawning hole, but without having shared a specific plan that doesn’t resort to the layoffs he wants to avoid.

“My responsibility as executive is to present a budget that reflects the

Turn to Deficit, Page 6



Mayor Brandon Johnson has signaled that he can help fill the 2026 budget gap if those with means “contribute more to the vitality of the city,” and that the city could make cuts without necessarily laying off workers. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Nell Salzman and Kate Perez
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Board of Education approved Chicago Public Schools’ 2025-26 budget without taking out a \$200 million high-interest loan, despite Mayor Brandon Johnson’s push to include borrowing as an option to close the district’s massive funding gap.

The 12-7 vote, with one abstention, followed months of financial warnings from top CPS officials and marked a notable shift in internal board dynamics. The decision came just days after Johnson appointed Ángel Vélez to the hybrid, partly elected, partly appointed board, hypothetically securing the simple majority needed to pass a budget with borrowing.

When district leadership presented a \$10.25 billion budget to the board earlier this month, multiple board members — supporters of the mayor — dismissed it.

Turn to CPS, Page 4

\$1.15B

Mayor Brandon Johnson says the city faces a deficit of more than \$1 billion, which grew by \$146 million after CPS remained “uncertain” on repaying pension costs.

\$734M

CPS itself faces a deficit of more than \$700 million, which the school district has been trying to solve through refinancing, layoffs and cuts to services.

\$379M

Instead of using loans, CPS’ \$10.25 billion budget relies on \$379 million not yet secured in extra TIF funds, but that comes with uncertainty, mayoral allies argue.

Housing authority asked to delay hire

HUD says it wants to probe possible conflicts of interest

By Lizzie Kane
Chicago Tribune

U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development officials asked the Chicago Housing Authority Thursday to postpone moving forward with an appointment of former Ald. Walter Burnett as CEO because of a need to review potential conflicts of interest, a HUD official who was not authorized to speak on the record told the Tribune.

The move was in response to a letter interim CHA Board Chair Matthew Brewer sent to the federal agency Wednesday that outlined Burnett’s potential conflicts. The same day it sent the letter, the CHA board scheduled a special meeting for Tuesday to appoint the new CEO, according to its board meeting schedule.

HUD officials told CHA the federal agency is currently evaluating the contents of the letter and that it already has some concerns. HUD will need some time to review CHA’s letter and formally respond, the official said, as the local general counsel office must review the CHA’s letter.

The official anticipates that HUD will require CHA to request a waiver for a number of conflicts of interest in Burnett’s case. The local HUD office would then need to review the waiver request, send its recommendation for the waiver to HUD’s Washington headquarters for additional review and send a formal response to CHA, the official said.

If CHA does move forward with Burnett’s appointment without HUD’s

Turn to CHA, Page 4

CHICAGOLAND

Advocates: ‘Stand with us’ amid takeover threat

With federal agents reportedly set to use the Naval Station Great Lakes in North Chicago as their jumping-off point for an upcoming blitz in Chicago, immigrant advocates gathered nearby Friday to urge people to prepare for the looming threat.

Fujian groups from across the US gather in Chicago to celebrate heritage and, with such a widespread diaspora, find ways to sustain community



‘THIS IS MY FAMILY’S STORY’

By William Tong | Chicago Tribune

Knife and fork in hand, Cassie Lin sliced off a corner of her pizza — packed with thick layers of mozzarella, mushrooms and pepperoni — and took a bite. A visitor from Texas, it’s Lin’s first time trying Chicago deep dish. Her reaction was mixed.

“It’s very good,” Lin said in between bites, covering her mouth with her hand. “It’s very cheesy, very meaty.” Another bite. She chewed it over. “Is it too late to say I’m lactose intolerant?” asked Lin.

Lin, 18, is a college student from the Houston area and she’s no ordinary tourist. She was here with her mom, aunt, uncle and cousin as part of the first organized, large-sized gathering in Chicago of immigrants and their descendants from the Fujian province of China.

Known as Fujian hometown associations, at least a dozen such groups from across North America gathered in and around Streeterville over the past week to participate in the convention, which was made up largely of tourist activities, showcasing the best of what the city has to offer, and culminating with a gala Thursday night at Navy Pier.

Nearly 100 people came together to celebrate shared culture and brainstorm ways to stay connected as a community.

For Dr. Kim K. Tee, 61, an organizer of this week’s convention, the event was a great way for different associations to join forces and strategize about recruitment. Tee was also excited to introduce visitors to his home of more than 40 years, he said.

“I want to show them not only Chicago, but culturally what Chicago has to offer,” said Tee, who lives in South Loop.

That had to, of course, include

Turn to Fujianese, Page 2

Top: Lily Lo, left, and Crystal Lo decide to get more pizza as a Pizzeria Due server helps them during a meal sponsored by a North American Fujianese association in Chicago on Thursday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

